

Raw Interview with queer immigrant

Person 1:

1. From your hometown (very special geo/very multi-culture/language) to a place with relatively single culture, what changes have occurred in your philosophy, world view, or your body?

I've got the chance to get from a place where collective thought is something considered to be almost sacred to a place where it's less sacred and finally to a place where individuality could be the driving motivator for someone's actions or decisions. Having heard someone speak a mix of dialects to a place where you could almost understand anyone is a sensory experience that I've noticed since I've come to the U.S. Some senses have been toned down, giving a piece of mind, but some have been annoyed to a point where avoidance becomes a routine. Supermarket trips, amazon searches for any single product, going to a restaurant and everything else has become a game of comparison and evaluation. More than products, individuality is a point of comparison. How being where you are from becomes a topic of conversation most of the time you go outside or how you could just learn to not think about that at all by being blind to any community?

Very little people know about my country and what region it even is in, so when I came here I didn't expect anyone to bother to learn or to do their research. I was taught that it's a common thing, but never taught why. As a kid TVs would tell you that it's just a comedic episode while you are back home and it's only a matter of education while you're in the States. This not only applies to where I am now, but it also projects itself onto the "neighbor" country that people like to call the elder brother country: Türkiye (or Turkey per its old name). The same kind of alienation in a much more subtle note was something that I noticed in the six years I've lived there. You get used to it, because it's harder to change a set of ideals of a group by explaining what they are doing is wrong than just laughing it off and knowing that you won't be here for too long. The alienation that I'm talking about is an othering that manifests itself not clearly in stereotypes but in the behaviors of the people around you. On one hand there's the States that makes assimilation a task for the immigrants themselves, by secluding a community in order to preserve it and on the other hand there is Türkiye, where the idea of being a turkic adjacent country turns you into a Turkish person, removing an identity that was shaped by centuries of colonialism by the said group and more, trauma and erasure. So moving to the U.S, was a change in perspective and how I value my own identity not in relation to other identities, but in the context of existing under empires and what it means to always be a smaller group of people in most contexts. I often joke with my friend, who's also here, that I regard Armenians closer to me in a lot of ways than I do Turkish people. Which would be an unpopular opinion given the climate of perspectives and general outlook. We share the same food, same culture, same dances, same sentiments and same trauma. Maybe not on the same scale, but I would be more understood by someone who my country has been in a bitter taste with for decades, than a country that sees me and my people as a resource. Obviously, the actions of the government doesn't translate to people, but it enforces a narrative hard to escape for a lot of people. It almost puts you in a position of not being able to disagree.

My body, my body...I would say it's been yearning for the sea and the mountains extremely much. It's always the case whenever you leave your country you just keep missing it more, but the case with this is that the moment you leave you realize that those trees, those rivers don't belong to you. That it becomes something so classist that enjoyment of even nature becomes a struggle amidst so many problems this country gives. My body misses my home, my parents, my grandma, my siblings, my aunt and my cousin. It misses the same salted air that I breathed for 17

years before I left. Explains my sodium imbalance and my thirst for water, but doesn't explain how I feel at times at 2AM during the night.

2. Why did you leave Baku?

I left Baku when I was 16, turning 17. I grew up with the constant of fear of what it would mean to stay back home and what it would cost me and people around me. My parents themselves, grew up in the Soviet Union, they know the people in charge better than me and my idea of them never was the greatest. From the economical hardships of my family to aggressive anti-queer sentiment in the country and from less opportunities by a dictatorial monopoly to military service, there are a lot of reasons to list why I left Baku. I can't go on for each of them, but they might give an idea. My mom tells me something I don't recall saying but when I was 14-15, I would tell them that I'm going to go to New York and live there even if I had \$100 of cash with me, that I would still do it because it's something I wanted from watching movies and regularly consuming western media. Is the actual reason me manifesting it? I can hardly tell. A lot of young people like me leave the country saying that "why would I give something back to this country when it never gave anything to me when I was growing up?". A very valid sentiment that I still somewhat believe in. I had the privilege to go to amazing schools with scholarships, thanks to what my parents taught me and them making us a priority in their lives. I remember having classmates who would order McDonalds for their lunch break in a time where delivery apps weren't a thing back home. I inherently grew up with a class difference and my mom taught me that "Money can't buy the will to learn". And this country didn't give me something to learn, it gave me lessons only. Nepotism flowing from every single part of the government and job boards, I didn't have much chance to do the things that I can do now or would even know about to be inspired by and aspired to. A lot of people leave this country because they aren't being valued as they would want to be, nor their expressions are seen as valid because of so many factors.

Person 2:

1. 介绍/research一种代表幸福感的建筑结构。

“四面荷花三面柳，一城山色半城湖。”垂柳依依，家家户户门前轻拂，泉水潺潺，流过青石板路，仿佛岁月的低语。众山环绕，北方的粗犷与江南的柔美在此碰撞，泉眼涌动，汹涌却平静，像是大地的呼吸。

“常记溪亭日暮，沉醉不知归路。兴尽晚回舟，误入藕花深处。”

“花自飘零，水自流。”

时光在这片水乡中悄然流逝。

李清照笔下的济南，是从异国归来时，才猛然意识到的，扑面而来的家的味道。那味道、景色、温度、声音，以及风吹过肌肤的触感，还有深植于每个济南孩童心中的泉水旁嬉闹的记忆，都在那一句“常记溪亭日暮”中，变得清晰而温暖。

朝起朝落，古城坐北朝南，经纬交错，气派非凡。曾经的雄伟城墙或许已支离破碎，但水路依旧滋润着城市的脉络。烟雨朦胧中，现代与古代的水墨在此交汇。从南向北，穿过泥泞的山脉，顺着山泉水，步入城市的森林。在一个不经意的转角，路两旁的梧桐树在天际交汇，待天空再次展露时，清风拂柳，红绿交错。

那红，来自于对城墙的固有印象。这印象并非源于我的亲身记忆，济南府的城墙通常并非通体红墙，而是青红交错，略带江南的韵味。红墙的印象，多少是受到政府宣传的影响，却在我脑海中形成了与家相关联的幸福象征。红墙、青瓦、柳树、竹林、泉水、锦鲤、明湖、月色、青山、寺庙、橘猫……这些元素，即使只有两两相伴，也能勾勒出家的意味。

2. Question 2：你所认同的一种哲学观是怎样的？从中庸的角度谈论对激进左派的批评？来自不同文化背景的认知屏障？这种屏障是如何逐步形成的？“自由是用来激怒人群的。”对于愤怒的批判。对于资本主义/新自由主义的批判。

中庸之道，是人生的大道，是事业成功、生活安定、健康长久的根本法则。
它的核心可以概括为三个层面：

第一层：中不偏，庸不易。

“中”意味着不偏离轨道，“庸”意味着持守恒常。人生若能不因外界的风吹草动而轻易改变目标与信念，便掌握了成功的关键。孔子曾说：“中庸之为德也，其至矣乎！民鲜久矣。”这句话意指，中庸之道是一种至高无上的美德，只是世人很久未能真正践行。

第二层：中正、平和。

人需持守中正平和，若是情绪过盛——喜怒哀乐皆失衡，便容易陷入困顿。治怒，当以乐解；治喜，不可逾礼。礼的根本，在于敬。心存敬畏，则能保持内心的平衡，身心亦得以安康。

第三层：中，意指美好；庸，意指实用。

一个人应当有所专长，成为一个对社会有用的人；同时，也要坚守自己的职责，在其位，谋其职，不妄动，不妄言。

我认同中庸之道，尤其是第二层的“中正、平和”。人生难免被情绪裹挟，喜怒哀乐轮番登场，然而，过喜失态，过怒伤身，唯有内心的敬畏能使人回归平衡，长久维持身心的安定。

01

我记得，18岁初到美国时，我对美式左派充满了好奇。那时的我，像是一张未经染色的白纸，而左派的信息无孔不入，只要身处这片土地，便难以不受其影响。

18岁，是世界观逐步成型的年纪。面对铺天盖地的舆论，我开始自然地相信，自由与平等是理所当然的信条。集会、游行，这些对于来自中国内地的我而言，既陌生又新奇。我所熟悉的“运动”在我的成长经历中是被压制的，却又隐隐透着正向的意义。那时的我笃信，若要改变什么，就必须默默耕耘，忍辱负重，以长远的计划实现目标。

我记得第一次看到 queer parade时，那种震撼至今未曾忘记。在光天化日下，他们冲破宗教的桎梏，以怒吼强调自己的存在。即便只是站在游行的外围，我仍能感受到愤怒所带来的磅礴力量——原来，愤怒竟可以如此鼓舞人心。那时的我并未察觉其中的复杂性，毕竟，18岁是个容易被情绪裹挟而不加深思的年纪。

02

转眼间，已是我在美国的第八年。八年里，我见证了川普的第一任期、疫情的爆发、拜登上台、再到川普卷土重来。这期间，中国也经历了对同性恋群体的政策变化、中美金融战、疫情封控后的 **白纸运动**，以及中美 **AI 竞争**。这一切，让我开始敬畏愤怒的力量，也开始反思自由的边界，渐渐走向中庸之道。

2019 至 2020 年，我在中国经历了疫情的第一波。2021 年，我返回美国完成学业，2022 年毕业后再次回国，亲历了 **第三轮疫情**、**白纸运动** 及 **全面放开**。这一连串的经历，彻底改变了我对“自由”的理解。

我记得 白纸运动时的愤怒。互联网让我看到了太多的苦难，我愤怒，质问，失望。然而，我也清楚地记得 **全面放开** 后的那个冬天。那一周，街上满是灵车，亲友相继离世的消息接踵而至。

那一刻，我意识到自己的渺小。作为一个在新一线城市长大的中产阶级小孩，我曾以为自己看得足够远，足够透彻，却从未真正理解一个发展中国家的困境。我忽略了财政的局限、人口的庞大、医疗资源的失衡，以及五亿贫困人口的现实。这让我猛然惊觉，自由，或许只是一个伪命题。和“平等”一样，它是一个煽动情绪的最佳词汇，却未必真实可及。

03

I feel like a fish sometimes
Swimming along the ceiling in flowing rooms
Walls shimmering with ripples
Where reality never reveals

My parents want me to be a tiger
Living in mountains full of woods
Borned in a tiger year
They added 山mountain and 木wood to my name

I am secretly a tiger
Constantly seeking for my own territory
Never fulfilled
Never free

I wish I can be nothing

Then I can be free from
searching for home

05

山东是个相对有特点的地方。仁、义、礼、智、信、恕、忠、孝、悌像一座大山压在这片土地上。儒家思想有着很明确的规矩礼数，同时也有着很大的空间，在山东这些空间即是可喘息的又是可被利用的。不可否认的，我也因我家传承的相对不严苛的儒家礼教受益过，它教会了我这片土地上人与人的界限，社会文化上的规矩，我的大家族也常常相聚、互相关照，每个人在每个人被安排好的位置上各司其职。但同样，不可否认的，它将我们深深困在这里，每个人都时常压抑自己。我爷爷给我写过一本书，里面记录了我们家族的家训、对我的教诲和期盼。书中描绘的我，陌生又熟悉，我是我爷爷眼中喜欢尝试新鲜事物的小孩，也没有他认为的是个懂事的小孩。儒学的观点，单看一个的话是没有杀伤力的，但当他们聚合在一起，就不是望人为君子，而是妄人为神。这样的“神”性，即使在我留学的第三个年头也未能摆脱，为此我过着不喜欢的人生，学着不喜欢的专业，陪伴着剧本里规定好的人，时刻遵循君子之道。山东姑娘的剧本多半相似，毕业找一个好单位，寻一门当户对的良人，结婚生子，安稳的度过一生。

我的身体对此产生了极大的抗拒。这种抗拒是一直存在的，即使旧剧本代表了一部分来自家人的关心与支持，但当它的声音如此之大，当儒学参与了太多自我价值观搭建的时候，我甚至看不到我身体的需求。我还记得七岁时，妈妈送给我一双带着小鞋跟的靴子搭配着打底裤和一件毛绒绒的高领白毛衣，当她期待着我穿上时，我嚎啕大哭。我身体的抗拒在她的催促下瞬间爆发。在一顿大吵大闹后，我妈妈不解又失望的退掉了衣服。8岁时我开始喜欢篮球，2006年的山东，大部分的小学还没有成立女篮队伍。那个年代篮球足球有着强烈的性别指代，就像跳皮筋、踢毽子、排球等一样被赋予了明确的性别指向。我剪了头发、穿着队服，学着他们说脏话、打架，会习惯性的称兄道弟、还会时而走路踮脚、时而又假装绅士，好像必须成为这样，我才属于球队这个小群体，实际上我性格并不是如此。后来，五年级时班里转来了一位女生，她来的第一天我们就成为了朋友，一直到小学毕业我们几乎无时无刻粘在一起，一起大哭大笑，成为了那段时间最了解彼此的人。但她和我一样，被旧剧本裹挟着，我们都没有意识到我们是为何互相吸引。

这些事情即使在我17年初到美国，认识到同性恋群体之后，也没有激起我的意识。直到2020年，我因为疫情原因被迫gap半年回国回家。不得不在家又基本无所事事的日子倒是提供了思考的空隙。2020年，我在日记里写到——

有一段时间没有写东西来发泄心情了

越长越大知道了自己是个情绪抵御能力很差的人 我总是不能轻易的开心 轻易的难受

像今夜这个下完雨清爽的夜晚 刚经历了充实的一天 和好朋友吃饭喝咖啡溜达聊天 以及和远在成都的好友愉快的发消息 11点就准备好上床睡觉 甚至连明天都充满期待 的夜晚 却胸口发闷 眼睛湿润

这些年 越来越搞不懂自己 也许是拒绝承认自己 我经常说 编程是个好专业能赚钱 然后就将这块石头压在了胸口 事实是 它掌握了我的未来 他让我看到了我不想要的未来 我想学艺术 我想要一个表达情绪的媒介 可我不会画画不会弹琴 说到这里 如果外人在读 大概都会劝我 那就好好学编程吧 所以为什么呢 我擅长的东西偏偏是我讨厌的东西

你说 嘿 下面是不是该扬了 一般文字走到这里就要看我给自己的答案了吧 欲扬先抑嘛 恩 我还没有答案 所以如果是个作家 那她不会现在就写下这些文字 她一定找到了答案 才来分享 可我不是在写给别人啊 是写给迷茫 无助的当下 当然 让我会打开备忘录 花时间敲下这些字的肯定不再是这简单的问题了 还有交织在一起的矛盾和那该死的 该死的不安全感

写到这里 我发现它已经从内向外的吞噬了我 连这备忘录 我自己的空间 我都无法把它打出来 打出来了 就好像变成了真实 我知道那是我 可我却还没办法接受承认更不要说 自信的自由的带着那个标签出现

当年的五月份，中国的防控政策起效，全国各地逐渐放开，大家都激动的走出家门恢复社交。有时候事情很神奇，当我处在最需要人推我一把的临界点，这个人就会出现。在同一片区域长大的人，很多文化相关的压抑不需要表达也能互相理解，她会给我分享女同电影歌曲，圈内话题，我也意识到，之前在欧美接触了LGBTQ+文化多年却没有唤起性向意识的原因是，我们的文化语境和抗争的对象有太大差异。所以短暂的回到家，我才重新成长。认清取向之前爱一个人的感觉是模糊的 总是会反问自己 这是他们所说得心动吗 这个时刻我是不是该感到伤心了 这就是感情了吗 我像是鱼缸里的鱼 看不清 听不清 重力失衡

这些 在她小心又坚定的抓住我的手时 即刻破碎
地球开始自传 引力瞬时作用
我在停滞的边缘 极力呼吸

那段时间之后我开始意识到很多事情，我的身体和我的心都深深融入在了这片土地上，只有这里的土壤和这片土地上的故事才真正的孕育了我。连我想要抗争的，都深深的与这里相关。我的故事，也因在这片土地上，才有了意义。